> during the EXCOM discussions, I never heard an expression of fear of nuclear escalation on the part of any of my colleagues. If at any time we were sitting [on] the edge of Armageddon, as nonparticipants have sometimes alleged, we were too unobservant to notice it.[14]

Ormsby-Gore certainly discussed nuclear weapons with the President in their meeting on 21 October. Yet the Presidential Recordings suggest that Taylor's recollections are not in error (although he was not in the room when Dean Acheson delivered his ideas on escalation in Europe). Certainly, there was no discussion of waging nuclear war when Kennedy met the Joint Chiefs on 19 October (despite previous discussions they had). Written records provide little indication of serious discussion about launching a nuclear attack.

Maxwell Taylor's observation concerned discussion in ExComm. Martin Sherwin draws attention to a meeting of the Joint Chiefs on Wednesday, 17 October, and to a little-remarked exchange between Taylor and McNamara. General Taylor stated that 'he did not share McNamara's fear that if we used nuclear weapons in Cuba, nuclear weapons would be used against us'.[15] How significant was this discussion? Sherwin asks whether it reveals the Joint Chiefs proposed attacking the missile sites with nuclear weapons. Did the President learn of the proposal? Were there other discussions? Is this something the Joint Chiefs talked about between themselves when McNamara and Gilpatric were not in the room? Is it an example of something of huge importance that has escaped the attention of historians because care was taken to avoid leaving a record (in which case absence of evidence is not evidence of absence)? This is certainly something that we now know that we do not know.

Plan R

In *Dr Strangelove,* when President Muffley learns that the 843rd Bomb Wing is on its way to attack the Soviet Union, he tells General Turgidson: 'I find this very difficult to understand, general. I am the only one who has